

Australia Chair Daily Brief

AUSTRALIA · NEW ZEALAND · THE PACIFIC ISLANDS

Tuesday, September 8, 2026

RE: \$1b Solomons treaty leak roils Honiara-Canberra ties · Sogavare alleges Australian interference · US scientist and Chinese training deepen Cook Islands seabed contest · Fiji constitution report to Cabinet · RBA deputy governor warns of further hikes

ASX 200 **8,921** -1.61% AUD/USD **0.7216** +0.97% NZX 50 **13,793** +0.04% NZD/USD **0.5846** -0.85%

BRENT **98.38** +2.88%

TODAY AT A GLANCE

- 1 Leaked text messages show Canberra pursuing a roughly \$1 billion treaty with Solomon Islands, with an in-principle agreement now reached and former prime minister Manasseh Sogavare alleging Australian interference.
- 2 China's ambassador to the Cook Islands reaffirmed Beijing's seabed minerals training support as Washington prepares to station a NOAA scientist in Rarotonga from November.
- 3 Fiji's Constitutional Review Committee hands its report on the 2013 Constitution to Cabinet this week, reopening questions over a Christian state and the role of chiefs.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY

Leaked texts reveal \$1b Australia-Solomon Islands treaty push

Leaked text messages reveal details of a new \$1 billion treaty Prime Minister Anthony Albanese wants to strike with his Solomon Islands counterpart, SMH reported. Solomon Islands fended off a no-confidence motion this week, which the paper described as a blow to Beijing and a coup for Albanese. Islands Business separately reported that Australia has struck an in-principle agreement with Solomon Islands for the new treaty.

So what: An in-principle agreement moves the treaty toward signature, extending Australia's run of bilateral Pacific security instruments.

Pattern: Australia's treaty run reached Fiji on September 5, 2026, per this brief's China in the Pacific ledger.

per SMH Federal Politics (Matthew Knott): "'Seize this opportunity': Leaks reveal \$1b pledge to counter Beijing's Pacific reach" · also Islands Business

US-CHINA-PACIFIC

China reaffirms Cook Islands seabed backing as US scientist heads to Rarotonga

China's ambassador to the Cook Islands, Wang Xiaolong, reaffirmed Beijing's support for seabed mineral exploration through continued custom training programmes and ocean research surveys, RNZ Pacific reported. Asked whether China would also station a scientist in country, Wang told Cook Islands News that the US posting was largely for capacity building and that China had been running comparable exercises. NOAA's Dr Nicole Bartlett, a US Embassy Science Fellow, will be based in Rarotonga from November to advise the Seabed Minerals Authority.

So what: Both capitals will now have technical advisers alongside Cook Islands regulators as the country moves through its deep-sea mineral exploration phase.

per RNZ Pacific: "China reaffirms seabed minerals support as US prepares to station scientist in Rarotonga - RNZ"

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Fiji constitutional review report heads to Cabinet

The Constitutional Review Committee report on Fiji's 2013 Constitution, installed by the government of Frank Bainimarama, goes to Cabinet this week after more than six months of consultations, ABC reported. The report is not yet public but has already drawn attention over a Fijian Christian state and the role of chiefs in politics. Fijian Broadcasting Corporation reporter Mosese Raqio said the handover was an important step but that implementation would be harder: "These are not simply technical questions."

So what: Cabinet's handling of the draft constitution determines whether Fiji reopens its secular settlement before the next election cycle.

per ABC Politics: "Fiji constitutional review to be handed to Cabinet this week - ABC News & Headlines – Australian Broadcasting Corporation"

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Wong prepares new Israel sanctions but rules out trade ban

Foreign Minister Penny Wong is preparing new sanctions against Israel but will not impose a trade ban, SMH reported. Former Labor minister Ed Husic hailed the British plan to ban economic activity with Israeli settlements as a "seismic movement by one of our close allies." The distinction leaves Australia short of the settlement-trade measures Britain has adopted.

PACIFIC-DIPLOMACY · ABC NEWS

ABC questions value for money in Australia's Solomon Islands spending

About a dozen Australian government billboards occupy prime positions off Honiara's main road, promoting the partnership in English and Solomon Islands pijin with slogans including "Nambawan patna long sekiuriti," ABC reported. The billboards proliferated after 2019's switch of recognition to Beijing. The piece asks whether the billion-dollar treaty approach delivers value for money in the contest with China.

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

RBA deputy governor says people are 'furious' about inflation

The Reserve Bank's deputy governor warned that interest rates could rise further if inflation does not come under control, ABC reported, saying people are furious about price rises. The Australian separately reported the RBA signalling

more rate hikes may be needed, calling inflation the bank's top priority. The cash rate was held at 4.35 percent on August 11, 2026.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Albanese unveils draft Digital Duty of Care laws

Labor released draft Digital Duty of Care legislation requiring platforms to block certain content from children, take proactive steps to prevent harm, and let users opt out of algorithmic feeds. Communications Minister Annika Wells is handling the bill, which Albanese branded "my feed, my way." Opposition Leader Angus Taylor and others in the Coalition have raised censorship concerns.

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Bowen commits Albanese to attending UN climate summit

Climate Change and Energy Minister Chris Bowen has committed the Prime Minister to attending the UN climate summit, The Australian reported. A companion piece reported Bowen declining to accept sole responsibility for the outcome as Albanese weighs his attendance.

PACIFIC WIRE

SOLOMON ISLANDS · SMH FEDERAL POLITICS

Sogavare accuses Australia of foreign interference

Former Solomon Islands prime minister Manasseh Sogavare said he is "deeply concerned" Australia has been meddling in his country's internal politics after the publication of leaked text messages, SMH reported. Sogavare's intervention follows the collapse of the no-confidence push against the current government.

NEW CALEDONIA · ABC PACIFIC

New Caledonia leans on indigenous crops amid post-unrest downturn

New Caledonia is still recovering from 2024's civil unrest, which cost billions of dollars and crippled tourism, ABC reported. The territory's new government is pushing to rebuild while outer island communities rely on native crop growing. Vanilla producer Waze Marciel said on Lifou that "life isn't costly because we rely on ourselves cultivating everything."

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Forum leaders endorse Kava declaration and fisheries fund review

Forum leaders endorsed a Kava declaration, a fisheries fund review, and a regional labour ministers process, Islands Business reported in its PACNEWS bulletin. The same bulletin carried the Green Climate Fund's call to "make Pacific economies more resilient" and confirmed Australia's in-principle treaty agreement with Solomon Islands. The Federated States of Micronesia will host the 80th CRGA in Pohnpei in 2027.

FIJI · ABC PACIFIC

Two of 17 derelict ships removed from Suva Harbour

Two vessels have been removed in the first step of a six-month effort to clear 17 derelict ships from the reefs of Suva Harbour, ABC reported. Minister responsible for Environment and Climate Lynda Tabuya said each vessel must pass a strict cleaning and inspection process before safe scuttling, and that cutting them to scrap for export would be longer and costlier.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC

PNG police hunt gang over ransom kidnapping in Western Province

Police in Papua New Guinea's Western Province are searching for a gang accused of kidnapping two teenage girls from a village in the remote Mogulu area, one of whom was allegedly murdered after four days while the other escaped. Provincial Police Commander David Warap said the alleged kidnappers came from neighbouring Hela Province and that police urgently need more resources near the border.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Watchdog finds PNG district authorities spending billions without oversight

District development authorities are spending billions of kina without basic oversight, according to a watchdog report cited by the Post-Courier. The paper summarised the findings as no budgets, no audits, and no checks.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · RNZ PACIFIC

Devpolicy paper maps Facebook's role in PNG sorcery violence debate

A Development Policy Centre discussion paper analyses how Facebook shapes debate over sorcery accusation-related violence in Papua New Guinea, RNZ Pacific reported. An estimated 200 people are killed by such violence each year. Lead researcher Professor Miranda Forsyth of the Australian National University said Facebook is the country's dominant digital public sphere. A Melanesian Institute survey last month found nearly three quarters of respondents rely on social media for news of the violence.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Fiji reports rise in influenza-like illness

Fiji has recorded a marked rise in influenza-like illnesses and acute respiratory infections over the past three weeks, Islands Business reported.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

National swaps bed tax for redistributed visitor levy

Prime Minister Christopher Luxon, Louise Upston and Nicola Willis announced National would reset International Visitor Levy allocations instead of introducing a bed tax, RNZ reported. From July 2027, \$100 million would go to the Department of Conservation, \$50 million to tourism growth and resilience, and the remainder to councils by visitor share. Auckland would receive an estimated \$19.1 million in year one and Queenstown Lakes \$17.1 million.

NZ-POLITICS · RNZ

Three of nine government targets at risk as Jobseeker numbers climb

Three of the New Zealand government's nine key targets risk not being met, RNZ reported, with 218,500 people on Jobseeker benefits against a 140,000 target. Emergency department performance sits at 74.4 percent of patients seen within six hours, against a 95 percent goal. Targets on emergency accommodation and assault or robbery victims have been met ahead of schedule. The nine targets, announced in April 2024, run to 2030.

NZ-FOREIGN-POLICY · BEEHIVE (NZ GOVT)

New Zealand and Japan sign emergency management cooperation memorandum

New Zealand and Japan signed a Memorandum of Cooperation on emergency management, with Minister Mitchell saying it "reflects our shared commitment to learning from one another and improving how we prepare for, respond to, and recover from future events." The statement marks 15 years since both the Great East Japan Earthquake and tsunami and the Christchurch earthquake.

NZ-POLITICS · ISLANDS BUSINESS

Peters backs citizenship test for Super and voting

Foreign Minister Winston Peters has backed a New Zealand citizenship test for superannuation and voting eligibility, Islands Business reported in its PACNEWS bulletin, which noted the impact on Pacific communities remains unclear.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

One Nation's Victorian leader admits past drug use

One Nation's Victorian leader Warren Pickering, 43, admitted using speed, ecstasy and marijuana in his 20s after his former partner spoke to The Australian. Pickering, who is contesting the seat of Pakenham at the Victorian election, said he stopped before joining the Australian Defence Force at 28 and disclosed the use when he applied. The Australian separately reported his drink-driving record and a repaid home owner grant.

AU-POLITICS · THE AUSTRALIAN

Taylor holds costed tax cut and super access plan

Opposition Leader Angus Taylor is sitting on a \$4 billion plan, developed under Sussan Ley, to fund tax cuts and unlock 3 percent of superannuation, The Australian reported. The disclosure lands as One Nation presses its own early super access proposal.

AU-DEFENSE · THE AUSTRALIAN

Prosecutors withhold 500 witness names from Ben Roberts-Smith

Prosecutors have withheld the names of 500 secret war crimes witnesses from Ben Roberts-Smith, The Australian reported.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · ABC NEWS

Australian 10-year bond yield near 15-year high

The interest rate on the Australian 10-year government bond is near a 15-year high, ABC reported, while US 10-year yields are the highest since the onset of the global financial crisis. Persistently elevated inflation would force rates higher or keep them uncomfortably high, pushing asset prices down and raising recession risk.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Firmus signs multibillion-dollar OpenAI deal before ASX float

Data centre operator Firmus has signed a multibillion-dollar deal with OpenAI ahead of a record ASX float, The Australian reported.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Transgrid tells data centres to fund network expansion

Transgrid says network expansions must be paid for by data centre owners, with Sydney effectively "sold out" of capacity, The Australian reported. The position sharpens the cost question for AI infrastructure investment in New South Wales.

PRIMARY DOCUMENTS

READOUT · TE AO MĀORI NEWS

Luxon wants to showcase Maori identity at Forum

Prime Minister Christopher Luxon said he wants to showcase Maori identity at the Pacific Islands Forum, Te Ao Māori News reported, noting the framing comes amid strained Crown-Maori relations.

READOUT · ABC PACIFIC

No-confidence motion against Solomon Islands PM withdrawn

The no-confidence motion against the Solomon Islands prime minister was withdrawn, ABC Pacific reported.

MINISTERIAL TRANSCRIPT · BEEHIVE.GOV.T.NZ

New Zealand extends support to Ukraine

The New Zealand government announced a continuation of its support to Ukraine, per a Beehive release.

CALENDAR WATCH

7 Nov 2026

New Zealand general election, advance voting from October 26

Determines whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it the current settings on Pacific and defence policy.

9 Sep 2026

Second day of White Australia's High Court challenge to federal hate speech laws

Judgment on the constitutional limits of the January hate speech laws is expected weeks or months after the hearing closes.

this week 2026

Fiji Constitutional Review Committee report goes to Cabinet

Cabinet's response sets the terms for any amendment of the 2013 Constitution.

from November 2026

NOAA Embassy Science Fellow Dr Nicole Bartlett takes up post in Rarotonga

Places a US technical adviser inside the Cook Islands Seabed Minerals Authority process.

expected 2027

FSM to host the 80th CRGA in Pohnpei

Brings the Forum's governing committee to Micronesia after this year's rift over the leaders meeting.

ALSO TODAY

DEVPOLICY BLOG

Vanuatu's literacy challenge: planting seeds of hope through national storytelling

Vanuatu's prime minister says 70 percent of children cannot read or write, Rebecca Olul-Hossen, Christelle Thieffry and Catherine Lessa write. They describe grassroots writing competitions, including the national Sot Sot Storian competition, nurturing ni-Vanuatu storytellers.

ABC NEWS

Australia records worst-ever PISA maths and reading scores

Australian 15-year-olds recorded their lowest scores on record in maths and reading in the 2025 PISA tests, while science stabilised, ABC reported. Australia ranked 10th in science and reading and 16th in mathematics among 91 countries and economies, remaining above the OECD average.

ABC NEWS

Eighth Australian found safe after Nepal-Tibet floods

An eighth Australian unaccounted for after the Nepal-Tibet floods has been found safe and was not in the disaster zone, ABC reported, leaving 35 still unaccounted for. Thirty-four of those were on the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage. Nepal's army said 121 people could be trapped in hydropower tunnels.

ABC PACIFIC

PNG blackouts leave hospital patients at risk

Constant blackouts damage business and endanger hospital patients in Papua New Guinea despite the country's renewable energy resources, ABC's Politok reported, featuring Energy Minister Thomas Opa and Port Moresby General Hospital oncology nurse Peter Fore. The edition repeated a program first broadcast on June 3, 2025.

ANALYSIS AND OPINION

LOWY INTERPRETER

An AI agenda for the India-Australia partnership

The piece argues Australia has data centre capacity to spare while India has AI demand it cannot meet. It frames the gap as a bilateral opportunity rather than a technical constraint.

Argument: Australia's spare data centre capacity and India's unmet AI demand are complementary and lack only a matching mechanism.

So what: Bears on how Canberra positions data centre and compute capacity in its economic diplomacy with New Delhi.

ASPI STRATEGIST

Japan and Australia can be a model for middle-power cooperation

The article holds that the Australia-Japan partnership stands out for complementarity across three spheres. It positions the two as leading Indo-Pacific democracies capable of anchoring wider middle-power coordination.

Argument: Australia and Japan bring complementary economic, political and security strengths and are among the middle powers best placed to drive Indo-Pacific cooperation.

So what: Relevant to the agenda for the next round of Australia-Japan ministerial engagement.

ASPI STRATEGIST

To lift capacity and save money, shift some fighter training to turboprops

The piece proposes inserting turboprop aircraft into the fighter training pipeline rather than relying on jet trainers throughout. It argues this would raise throughput and use resources more efficiently.

Argument: The Royal Australian Air Force could increase pilot training capacity and cut costs by using high-performance turboprops alongside jet trainers.

So what: Speaks to Air Force pilot production rates as the fast jet fleet's training demand grows.